

THE SMALL-FORMAT COFFEE PLAYBOOK

WHAT BLANK STREET TEACHES ABOUT COFFEE IN INDIA

The machine, the menu, and how to adapt the model in India for a tight budget. Company facts: Blank Street public reporting.

Blank Street Coffee went from one cart in Brooklyn in 2020 to nearly 90 stores and USD 127 million raised, by doing the opposite of what most cafes do: tiny stores, heavy automation, a lean menu, and prices just below the premium players. This playbook breaks down exactly how the model works, names the machine that makes it possible, dissects the menu, and shows how to adapt the model in India even on a tight budget.

THE COMPANY		Source: Blank Street public reporting
Fact	Detail	
Founded	2020, Brooklyn NYC. Started as a single battery-powered coffee cart.	
Founders	Issam Freiha and Vinay Menda. From finance/venture (previously ran Reshape, a ~\$100M fund), not F&B.; Inspired by small-format food retail in Asia.	
Total raised	~USD 127 million across 5 rounds from 17 investors.	
Key backers	General Catalyst, Tiger Global (co-led Series A). Angels: founders of Warby Parker and Allbirds; real-estate firm Tishman Speyer.	
Scale	~90 stores across US and UK (Sept 2025), targeting 150. Grew from 1 cart in under 5 years.	
Store format	Typically under 350 sq ft. Carts as small as 50 sq ft. Grab-and-go flow, 1-2 staff per shift.	

THE MACHINE		The core of the model
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The single most important and least-discussed part of the model is the equipment. Blank Street built the entire operation around a super-automatic espresso machine that removes the need for a skilled barista to pull every shot.

Specification	Detail
Brand	Eversys (Swiss). Searchable online, with dealers including in India.
Model — stores	Eversys Shotmaster (Shotmaster Pro / Pro Max line).
Model — carts	Eversys Cameo (compact format).
Approx cost	~USD 40,000-50,000 in the US (verify India landed cost with dealer).
Output	Up to ~700 espressos per hour.
How it works	Full drink, including steamed/frothed milk, at the push of a button. Recipe set once (e.g. 20g in, 40g out, 35-sec extraction), then repeatable with no temperature variation.

Why it matters	Removes the skilled-barista bottleneck. One store runs on 1-2 staff instead of 4-5. Consistency at peak hours. This is what makes the small-format economics work.
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Note: the machine is a large capital item. The economics only work at sufficient daily volume to justify it. At low volumes, a cheaper semi-automatic setup makes more sense. Model your expected cups/day before committing to this class of machine.

THE MENU

Lean, with one hero

The menu strategy is as important as the machine. It is deliberately lean, built around one hero category that drives the bulk of sales, priced just below premium specialty competitors.

Category	Role	Notes
Signature Matchas	THE HERO (~50% of sales)	Blueberry Matcha is the viral flagship. Also strawberry, vanilla, coconut, seasonal (ube, lavender). Visually striking, social-native.
Signature Lattes	Core coffee	Daydream, Blondie, iced vanilla, cold-brew twists. House syrups.
Cold Brew / Iced	Volume driver	Classic cold formats. Bestsellers in warm markets.
Hot Coffee / Teas	Base menu	London Fog, chai, standard espresso drinks.
Grab & Go food	Attach / margin	Small curated pastry and breakfast range. Not the focus.

The lesson: one visually striking, social-media-native hero product can carry roughly half of revenue. Ceremonial-grade matcha sourced from small Japanese farms gives a premium sourcing story on the hero. A "Regulars" subscription builds daily-ritual retention. Pricing sits ~25% below premium peers (e.g. ~\$3.75 for a 12oz latte).

How To Apply This In India

- One. Pick a high-footfall micro-location -- tech park, transit, college -- where grab-and-go volume is real. Small-format lives or dies on footfall, not ambience.
- Two. Prioritise high-street and high-visibility spots. A small unit on a busy high street with heavy walk-by traffic can outperform a large hidden cafe. Visibility does the marketing footfall would otherwise cost you.
- Three. Build the menu around one visually striking hero product, priced just below premium. Do not launch 40 SKUs. Launch a few, nail one.
- Four. Model your cups/day honestly before buying an automated machine. The Eversys-class machine only pays off at volume; start semi-automatic if volumes are unproven.
- Five. Keep staff lean by design -- the format and the machine should let 2-3 people run a shift. That is where the cost advantage comes from.
- Six. Use Instagram as the demand engine. Blank Street grew on visual, social-native drinks and app-based repeat ordering. The product has to be photogenic on purpose.